the Mirzas; and both victories are significant in many ways. Economically and culturally, the ports of Gujarat opened up whole new vistas for Akbar's empire, in terms of trade and interaction with Europe and the Middle East. Politically, it not only rid Akbar of an endlessly troublesome faction in the family, but also strengthened his bond with his Kachhwaha relatives. Eight of this Rajput clan came to Gujarat with Akbar, and many distinguished themselves.[19]

It was also now, at the beginning of his Gujarat campaign, that Akbar turned thirty. He was no longer the boy who put on a crown in the fields of Punjab, inconsolable at the loss of his father and uncertain where his future led. He was no longer, for that matter, the adolescent chafing at the concern and control of his guardians. He had spent over half his life on a throne. He helmed an empire that he was expanding all the way from the Ganga's waters to the Arabian Sea. Always prodigiously strong – there is a record of him punching a man unconscious at thirty-eight as he felled Adham Khan at twenty – Akbar would have been in peak physical condition in Gujarat.

And yet, it is also at about this time that Akbar shows his first fear of his own weakness. Only two years before he set off for Gujarat, Akbar was hunting wild asses in Punjab. The padishah shot thirteen asses in all – each time he got one, the herd ran further away, and Akbar followed. Caught in the chase, the hunter lost track of his companions and of his own thirst, until he found himself all alone, his throat so parched that he could not speak, let alone call out for help. It was now, Abul Fazl writes, that Akbar realized he should 'be more careful in guarding' himself.

The event was important enough, clearly, to deserve a record, and even a painting. In it, Akbar sits upon a cushion under a tree, his matchlock slung on one shoulder, his head tilted at a tired angle. His companions have found him: they are all delighted smiles, one of them rushes forward with a jug of cool water. But Akbar seems not even to see them. He is in a trance, it seems.[20]

What was it that shook Akbar so about being vulnerable and alone – shook him almost into an epiphany, as it appears from his faraway, meditative pose? Perhaps, alone as he had only been once before when he galloped away on the wild Hayran, Akbar realized how powerful he had become – and how powerless he remained, as weak as any man in the face of simple